

Tāq Kasrā

Location Ctesiphon, Iraq

The ancient imperial capital of Ctesiphon is known for the remains of its palace, the residence of the kings of the Sasanian Empire (c.224–651 CE). The palace's throne room is thought to have been 112 ft (34 m) high, 80 ft (24 m) wide, and 161 ft (49 m) long. However, the site's most distinctive feature is the Tāq Kasrā, or Archway of Ctesiphon, a remarkable, majestic structure, which formed part of the palace. At 121 ft (37 m) high and spanning around 85 ft (26 m), it is the largest single-span, unreinforced brick-built arch in existence. Its date of construction is disputed—historians are divided between the 3rd and the 6th centuries.

Temple of Henan

Location Dengfeng, China

Also known as the Shaolin Temple, the Henan Temple on Mount Song, Henan,



▲ THE KONDŌ AND FIVE-STORIED PAGODA OF THE HŌRYŪ-JI TEMPLE COMPLEX

Hōryū-ji Temple Complex

Location Ikaruga, Nara Prefecture, Japan

The earliest Buddhist monument in Japan, the temple complex of Hōryū-ji includes some of the world's oldest wooden buildings. The original temple (destroyed by fire in 670 CE) was constructed by Prince Shōtoku in 607 CE. Adapting Chinese style and temple layout to Japanese culture, and evolving over the centuries, the complex now comprises 48 buildings. Its masterpieces of wooden architecture include a five-story pagoda measuring over 105 ft (32 m) high, a two-story *kondō* (sanctuary hall), and the octagonal *Yumedono* (Hall of Dreams). Hōryū-ji contains more than 2,000 cultural artifacts and art treasures, including sculptures and murals, showing the influence of China, Korea, and India on the development of Japanese Buddhist art.

was one of the first centers for the translation of Buddhist scriptures in China. It also housed magnificent libraries and became a major monastery for Shaolin monks. However, it is best known as a principal site for the martial arts. Founded in around 495 CE, the Zen Buddhist temple has been destroyed and rebuilt many times. Covering around 620,000 square ft (57,600 square m), the complex

includes—from different periods—an entrance gateway; a bell tower; a drum tower; around 15 halls; an outer wall; and distinctive artworks, including statues, murals, and sculptures. A series of stelae recount the temple's history.

Yungang Grottoes

Location Datong City, Shanxi Province, China

A treasure trove of Buddhist cave art dating from around 460 to 520 CE, the Yungang Grottoes comprise 252 major caves containing around 51,000 statues. Stretching for about 0.6 miles (1 km), these magnificent cave sanctuaries, hollowed out of steep limestone cliffs, were probably influenced by the rock-cut traditions of India and Central Asia. Among the masterpieces at Yungang are gigantic Buddhist statues, including several of Chinese emperors; works depicting buddhas, *bodhisattvas*, and other sacred beings; and frescoes and vibrantly painted ceilings. The carvings inside the caves became more intricate and detailed over time.

